

TAMBARAM

Chromepet » Pallavaram » Tambaram West » Rajakilpakkam » Mannivakkam » Guindy » Keelkattalai » Nanganallur » Guduvanchery » Hasthinapuram » Pammal » Tambaram East

Medavakkam » Srinivasa Nagar » Kathipara Junction » Kovilambakkam » Sadasivam Nagar » Potheri » Selaiyur » Sembakkam » St.Thomas Mount » Madipakkam » Urappakkam » Paratur



BRING NORTHERN PARTS OF CHENNAI 'CLOSER' TO VELACHERY

Residents of 100 Feet Road note that MTC services from the southern parts of Chennai to the city's northern parts that passed through Velachery have dwindled **P4**



TRAVELLING LONG TO GET INKED

Over the last two to three weeks, migrant workers in Chennai have been etching travel plans to vote in their hometowns **P6**

Toilet complex at Kattankulathur station closed

Commuters want better infrastructure at the railway station, particularly an additional FOB and CCTV cameras

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

When commuters enter Kattankulathur station premises along GST Road, they are greeted by an overpowering and unpleasant stench. As the toilet complex is locked, commuters relieve themselves in the open, filling the air with that stench.

The premises is strewn with garbage and liquor bottles. Safety and safety measures at the station are inadequate.

S. Kayalvizhi, a commuter, says the Southern Railway should provide additional lighting on the premises. "The area around the toilet



complexes and the footbridge has become a haven for anti-social activities. I request the Railway to deploy Railway Protection Force (RPF) personnel and install CCTV

cameras to ensure commuters' safety," she says.

Dilapidated facilities

The existing footbridge infrastruc-



The stormwater drain network along the railway line at Kattankulathur railway station; the overflow from the network; and the toilet complex. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ture is in a dangerous state. The staircases are broken, and the walkways are damaged.

There are no lifts or escalators. Commuters are currently forced to climb over 70 steps to board electric trains towards Chennai Beach and Chengalpattu, which is physically exhausting for the elderly.

S. Anbusivam, a commuter, says, "There is a need for an additional footbridge at the end of the platforms to connect GST Road and Station Border Road. Currently, commuters and pedestrians risk their lives by crossing the tracks to entrain trains and to reach these roads. The pedestrians avoid taking a detour through LC 44 Road."

Commuters and pedestrians cross a stormwater drain network.

This path is littered with trash and is slippery, forcing the public to perform dangerous manoeuvres to cross without getting their legs wet. A new FOB would provide safe passage for both rail commuters and the general public. Commuters have asked Southern Railway officials to inspect the station premises.

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With CSR support, Ravi Kasi Venkatraman has transformed Maraimalai Adigal Government Higher Secondary School into a much-respected citadel of learning

LIFFY THOMAS

In 2021, when Ravi Kasi Venkatraman came on a transfer to Maraimalai Adigal (MMA) Government Higher Secondary School in Pallavaram, he was stepping into a difficult role. The new headmaster inherited a school with underdeveloped and poor infrastructure. There was nothing to write home about. The school enrolled students from classes VI to XII.

In five years, he has taken the institute to such heights that parents queue up to get admission for their children in the school, and the infrastructure built with CSR funds has left the corporates behind it proud.

Recently, Rotary Club of Madras honoured the HM with 'Educator Extraordinaire Award for 2025-26' for his contributions to education and community development.

The journey

One of the first areas of focus for the headmaster was to get functional clean toilets in the school with water supply, but he

noticed that the facility did not last long as students were involved in vandalising it. So before taking any major infrastructure work he wanted to win the confidence of students. Ravi who has a doctorate in Physics, rolled out initiatives to cater to all groups of students.

"In a school, you have some who are academically oriented, some only keen on sports, a few who do not like the atmosphere, so we started talking to them to understand their needs and this helped us instil some sense of belonging," says the 55-year-old HM.

The educator's rich experience of working with various schools in Tamil Nadu helped him get in touch with HCL Foundation, where he sought CSR funds. The 'Young Kalam Science Centre' on the one-acre school campus was developed in partnership with HCL Foundation, drawing many eyeballs as it is said to be among Tamil Nadu's first hands-on

science learning spaces designed to promote experiential learning. School Education Minister opened the Centre that raised eyebrows among the student community and teachers.

"In the last five years, more than 20,000 students across schools have visited the Science Centre," says Ravi.

He next reached out to Sriram Group of Companies for support as the classrooms had no fans and lights. In return, the Group took up ₹ 3 crore worth renovation of the campus, refurbishing all the classrooms and adding new amenities.

Through word of mouth, the infrastructure available in the school was known far and wide, and the management started seeing more parents enquiring about the school for admissions. To accommodate more students, Madras Round Table sponsored building additional classroom, around 12.



A tour of the school; and members of Rotary Club of Madras honour Ravi Kasi Venkatraman (in purple shirt) at the event.

ny of them send their employees to engage with our students and this way the rapport has only grown," says the academician, grateful to the support he has received from Parent Teacher Association, School Management Committee, alumni and teachers.

Engaging with parents

Likewise, all activities happening in the school are communicated to parents through an IVRS voice call. During exams, an alarm goes off at 5 a.m. on the mobile of parents that serves as a reminder for them to get their children to wake up and study. Students who bought laurels to the school were taken on a flight trip, a big moment as most of the children are from less-privileged backgrounds. A magazine listing out various initiatives taken by the management was another way to reach out to a wider audience.

The HM says they were able to get so many CSR partners as "Namma School Namma Ooru Palli", the portal promoted by the School Education Department, has an easy approval process.

MMA Government Higher Secondary School is next planning to set up a competitive exam centre, only one institute per block is selected for this under the 'Vetri Palligal' programme.

A bright spot that Ravi is proud of today is not denying the "so-called notorious" students admission. "Schools do not like to admit those who are infamous and we had many such cases before us. If we had denied them admission, they would have become anti-social elements in society. Instead we integrated them, nudged them to adopt changes in their behaviour and today a few of them are pursuing their undergraduate studies," he adds.

In 2024, Hyundai Mobis under its CSR funds agreed to construct a new auditorium and build four new classrooms.

"There are many other small groups that we reached out for funding who have equally contributed for the growth of MMA," he says. From 650 students in 2021, today the strength of the institute has almost doubled.

The school, in particular, is happy to see the number of girl students who are on its rolls. "From 100 girl students, today we have 450 on our rolls which I am proud of as empowering female students is our motto," says Ravi.

The school management follows a systematic approach in updating all its CSR partners and this has helped win their goodwill. "Any achievement of our students, big or small, we update our CSR partners. Ma-





▼ The approach road to Adambakkam railway station from Indira Nagar; and (right) Adambakkam MRTS station building near Vanuvampet junction. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A. RAMACHANDRAN

Adambakkam MRTS station on Velachery - Saint Thomas Mount line will open to commuters in the coming weeks.

Southern Railway should provide access to the station from the locality around, which would be very beneficial to commuters in the Nanganallur region. Besides, a parking lot should be provided.

‘Provide access from Nanganallur’

Commuters from Thillai Ganga Nagar (TGN), Sixth Main Road, 26th Street, 28th Street, 29th Street, 29th Street Extension, 47th Street, 48th Street, Ram Nagar Third Main Road, Seventh Street,

Eighth Street, Sixth Main Road, Eighth Main Road, Second Main Road, 11th Street, and Nanganallur Eighth Street, Ninth Street, Eleventh Street, Sixth Street, and 29th Street stand to benefit.

If not, commuters have three routes to navigate: through TGN Sixth Main Road, Nanganallur 24th Street, and North Main Road, Vanuvampet.

Commuters from Main Road and 24th Street can take a U-turn opposite the Street, and those from North Main Road can take a U-turn along Ram Nagar Third Main Road and Adambakkam Lake.

The station has two entrances: one along Medavakkam Main Road

(on the lane towards Mount railway station) and the other along Vanuvampet Street - Gandhi Street.

On the return route, commuters from both entrances have to go through Chidambaranar Street, Chidambaranar First Street, and Amman Koil Street, Vanuvampet, and Sixth Main Road, and 24th Street, Nanganallur. Pedestrians must cross the Southern Sector Inner Ring Road along the entrances, and a signaled pedestrian crossing must be provided.

The other option is to cross opposite Ram Nagar Third Main Road, or 24th Street.

The area along the station should be cleared of trash and construction debris, and a parking lot should be provided. Otherwise, commuters will board trains from the Saint Thomas Mount MRTS station.

A. Ramachandran is a resident of Nanganallur

Include Chitlapakkam in Chembarambakkam drinking water scheme

S. CHANDRASEKARAN

Palar drinking water supply to ward numbers 43 and 44, a section in Chitlapakkam of the Tambaram City Municipal Corporation, is highly irregular and inadequate.

Residents are facing severe hard-

ships as water is being supplied once a week and we have to rely on cans and reverse-osmosis plants.

Residents want regular and adequate water supply from Palar River by the Tamil Nadu Water Supply and Drainage (TWAD) board.

I suggest that the Chitlapakkam area be brought under the Chemba-

rambakkam integrated water supply scheme. The main line of the scheme extends to Rajendra Prasad Road in Chromepet, which is half a kilometre from the area.

This may be helpful to some extent. Moreover, our long-time demand for an additional overhead tank along Thirumurugan Salai, Ward 43, in an area adjacent to a ration shop, has also not been considered till now.

As the summer season has already begun, irregular and inadequate supply is forcing residents to buy water cans.

S. Chandrasekaran is a resident of Chitlapakkam

‘Reopen the toilet and also install a new one’

P. SATHYANARAYANAN

The Chennai Division of the Southern Railway has opened a new pay-and-use toilet at the Guindy railway station along Race Course Road. A similar one is needed at the terminal premises along Anna Salai. The facility at the end of platforms 1A, 1, and 2 at the terminal should be reopened.

At present, a common area outside the Guindy electric and metro train stations is being misused by people. Moreover, the area lacks lighting.

If a restroom is provided, it will be useful to metro rail commuters.

Chennai Metro Rail Limited and Southern Railway should set up a facility that



The locked washroom at Guindy railway station. Photo: Special Arrangement

would be useful to the public.

Otherwise, commuters and pedestrians (along Anna Salai) have to climb a flight of steps on the footbridge to reach the facility along Race Course Road.

P. Sathyanarayanan is a resident of Guindy

Electric crematorium needed in Sithalapakkam

S. ANAND

Absence of an electric crematorium in Sithalapakkam, part of Chengalpattu district, is a significant issue for the local people.

Approximately two to three lakh people live in the area, and they either go to Besant Nagar or Perumbakkam crematoriums. The Sithalapakkam burning ghat lacks benches, washrooms, shade and a place to perform rituals. Only the area where the bodies are cremated has a roof.

An electric crematorium has to be set up and should include these facilities.

S. Anand is a resident of Sithalapakkam



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Bring northern parts of Chennai 'closer' to Velachery

Residents of 100 Feet Road note that MTC services from the southern parts of Chennai to the city's northern parts that passed through Velachery have dwindled



MTC bus terminus at Vijayanagar junction in Velachery. PHOTO: SRINATH . M

B. GANGADHARAN

Residents of 100 Feet Road in Velachery find the northern parts of the Chennai slipping out of their range. And as residents are having a shopping list of chang-

es they want to see in the neighbourhoods, ready for candidates of political parties, residents of 100 Feet Road in Velachery are seeking that north Chennai be "brought closer" to them.

Many summers ago, travelling to areas such as Royapuram in north

Chennai did not take much of an effort as a raft of bus services were being operated to Broadway, Thiruvottiyur, Royapuram and surrounding areas from Sithalapakam, Ottiyambakkam, East Tambaram, Kovilambakkam, Madipakkam and Madambakkam,

through Velachery.

But today, the services are as good as non-existent, as only a handful of them are still on the road. Even these services are being operated only in the morning, and nowhere to be seen in the evening.

Route D51X, plying from Sithala-

pakkam, E51 from Ottiyambakkam, 51J from Madambakkam, and 51D from East Tambaram to Royapuram, is spotted only once in the morning at the Vijaya Nagar bus terminus, and in the evenings, these services do not ply.

Commuters from Velachery have to head to Little Mount to board buses to destinations such as Royapuram in north Chennai. To reach Thiruvottiyur, commuters have to disembark at the Chennai Central railway station bus stop or at the Royapuram terminus and board another bus.

I request the authorities at Metropolitan Transport Corporation to look into this issue and do the needful at the earliest to alleviate the problems faced by commuters from Velachery and the adjoining regions.

B. Gangadharan is a resident of Sakthi Vijayalakshmi Nagar, Velachery.

Commuters from Velachery have to head to Little Mount to board buses to destinations such as Royapuram in north Chennai. To reach Thiruvottiyur, commuters have to disembark at the Chennai Central railway station bus stop or at the Royapuram terminus and board another bus

Trust in Keelkattalai supports youth with athetoid cerebral palsy

Keelkattalai-based DSW Trust, working with children with special needs, has come forward to support Vijay, a young individual from Athoor in Salem, living with athetoid cerebral palsy.

Vijay's condition, characterised by involuntary movements and challenges in coordination and speech, has made his everyday activities a constant struggle. Under a special initiative called *Unmai Vellum*, the Trust has taken full responsibility for Vijay's essential needs, including physiotherapy, occupational therapy, speech therapy, vocational training, along with food and shelter, said a press release. DSW Trust has formed a specialised panel led by Dr. Saranya Ganesh to design and monitor Vijay's rehabilitation plan. He is given physiotherapy and structured interventions as part of a three-month programme tailored to Vijay's needs, said the release.

Lakshmi Ramakrishna and other experts are among others in the team. To enhance his rehabilitation and training sessions, Vijay currently requires essential assistive devices such as KAFO (Knee-Ankle-Foot Orthosis) and Dynamic Cock-up Splints. These supports are crucial in improving his mobility, posture, and functional independence during therapy and vocational training, added the release.

A huge relief for pedestrians



Finally, the FOB at Tambaram Sanatorium is getting a new lift and escalator. Workers hired by State Highways Department were seen installing the lift and the escalator on the lane towards Government Hospital on March 31. The technical team said the work on these facilities is almost complete, and they will be open to the public soon. The elevated pathway connecting Madras Export Processing Zone entrance area is being demolished. On the lane towards West Tambaram, work is under way to fix the escalator and to fit the lift. The facilities will ensure safe navigation between lanes (towards GH and West Tambaram). Below the bridge, work is on to lay a square tile stone pathway TEXT AND PHOTOS: T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN



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Associate Partners



Travelling long to get inked

Over the last two to three weeks, migrant workers in Chennai have been etching travel plans to vote in their hometowns. Associations representing them are seeking additional trains to ensure their long journey to the voting booth is smooth

LIFFY THOMAS

When election dates were announced on March 15, Kottivakkam resident and general secretary of Confederation of Tamilnadu Malayalee Associations Anwar M.P. was furiously scrolling down IRCTC website to book four train tickets to his hometown in Kannur district of Kerala. A resident of Chennai for the last three decades, the businessman makes travel plans to his native place every election season (that includes panchayat elections) sufficiently ahead of time.

Kerala goes to the hustings on April 9, as do Assam and Puducherry. Further down the “poll procession” are Tamil Nadu (April 23) and West Bengal (April

23 and 29).

Travel plans are being meticulously etched by residents of Chennai with their votes parked in other states. And associations representing the interests of those from these states who have “pitched tent” in Chennai for work and business note that with intervention by the Tamil Nadu government and Southern Railway, these travel plans need not be as stressful as they cur-

Poll-related travel plans are not always about tickets. Soaring prices of flight tickets around this time and lack of certainty about train tickets are encouraging voters to undertake long road trips to cast the ballot

rently are.

The Confederation of Tamilnadu Malayalee Associations has made a representation to the State Government to run additional trains to clear the rush of migrants wanting to vote in their hometowns. “This year, we made the representation more than two months ago so that there is ample time to press more trains into service,” says Anwar.

While Southern Railway does operate special trains during festivals and election season, many say the announcement on additional trains is made at the eleventh hour, which detracts from the usefulness of this exercise.

As Easter, Assembly Polls and Vishu come in quick succession, Anwar says there’s demand for bus and train tickets to Kerala.

Natvar Thidar, aged 44 and working as a cook in Chennai for the last 15 years, notes: “I paid extra money to an agent and got a confirmed ticket on Coromandel Express.”

“There are less number of trains to north Malabar and towards Mangalore, so we have made a representation to run trains on these routes in particular. We also need Vande Bharat on this network,” says Anwar.

A similar demand has been raised by the Assam Association Chennai, they want additional Durgam Express/Rajdhani Express/Vande Bharat Express to Guwahati.

Mini Bengal in Chennai

In Sowcarpet and Park Town, Tarun Kumar Das has been working with the community of Bengalis to encourage them to travel to their hometown to cast their vote. He says there are close to 30,000 Bengalis working mainly with

gold manufacturing outlets. “At least 70% of them have their vote in Bengal and we have already started speaking to them to see if they can start making arrangements to travel home,” says Das, who is vice-president of Rexine and Bag Manufacturer Traders Association - Tamil Nadu and vice-president of the Bengal Association.

Das says the Southern Railway must run additional trains to cater to such rush from people. “The construction industry employs a number of people from Bengal and there should also be some initiative from the industry so that they can also be part of elections,” he adds.

Tamil Nadu Labour Welfare and Skill Development Department has already issued instructions that all employers across industries and commercial establishments, including private sector, shops and factories, must grant paid holiday to employees, casual workers and daily wage earners to travel to their hometowns when voting happens in their states.

‘Vote vandi’

And poll-related travel plans are not always about tickets. Soaring prices of flight tickets around this time and lack of certainty about train tickets are encouraging voters to undertake long road trips to cast the ballot. Increasingly many people are seen coming together to hire a bus or van and travel together. Anwar says he has noticed this trend in the last three years, where people pool in money and book a vehicle that will reach their hometown on voting day and they return on the same bus. Adds Anwar: “They are called ‘vote vandi’ (vote bus).”



The Hindu EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair on April 11 and 12

The Hindu EducationPlus is conducting the 23rd edition of The Hindu EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair on April 11 and 12 from 10 a.m. to 6 p.m. at the Chennai Trade Centre, Convention Hall.

The exhaustive fair for parents and students from classes 9 to 12 will empower aspiring young minds to make informed career decisions from 40 plus institutions and help them choose the right courses and colleges.

Top educational and financial institutions from across India will be present. Furthermore, career guidance sessions with domain experts will help people discuss their career plans.

This annual fair is a great chance for students and parents to explore different career paths, learn about college admissions, and gain insights into various fields of study.

A plethora of options awaits students as they get ready to finish their schooling, much more than ever before. There are a wide range of courses to choose from, careers to aspire to, and areas of interest to delve into.

In every edition, the fair has aimed to give students insights into several areas, cater to their interests, and open a world of educational opportunities for them.



The latest edition of the career counselling fair will have all of this and make this experience possible for students by giving them the platform to engage with experts across diverse fields and representatives from various educational and financial institutions. Keeping up with the needs of the students, The Hindu EducationPlus has been organising career expos to aid students looking to pursue higher education both in India and overseas.

Spot admissions and scholarships await the students at the fair along with surprise gifts for the first 200 entries on both the days. To know more about the sessions and the fair, contact: +91 90940 41021, 9962226550 and 9841298938.

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Travel free on buses and trains to Chepauk

Like the previous years, Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) and Chennai Metro Rail Limited have launched an initiative to reduce traffic congestion and encourage people to use public transport on IPL match days in the city.

People with IPL match tickets can travel free on MTC buses (whiteboard and deluxe) for three hours before and after the match.

After the match gets over, MTC will operate buses from Anna Square bus terminus, Island Grounds (temporary) bus terminus, University of Madras haltover and near Omandurar Hospital on Anna Salai. From Anna Statue on Mount Road, MTC will operate shuttle services to the cricket stadium.

stadium.

Metro trains

People intending to travel on the Metro should possess a valid match ticket, said a CMRL release.

The ticket will enable a round-trip journey between their chosen stations and the Government Estate metro station.

Green line stations

The last train from the Government Estate metro station will depart at 1 a.m. towards Wimco Nagar Depot and Airport stations.

Commuters travelling towards green line stations (Corridor-2) shall interchange only at Chennai Central (during the special train services). The entry to the Estate station will be restricted 10 minutes before the last train for each line. The matches are scheduled to be held at M. A. Chidambaram Cricket Stadium in Chepauk.

Trials for Bhaichung Bhutia Football Schools today

Bhaichung Bhutia Football Schools (BBFS) will conduct scouting trials in Chennai to identify talented young student-athletes for the BBFS Residential Academy, the organisation's flagship high-performance football training and academic curriculum in association with reputed boarding schools across India. The trials will take place on April 5 at ANE Sports Arena. Participants are required to report at 8:30 a.m. Footballers born between 2010

and 2015 can participate.

Participants attending the trials must carry a valid government identity card for verification. They are required to report in full football attire, including jerseys, shorts, football boots, and shin guards, which are mandatory for participation. Athletes should also bring a personal hydration pack or water bottle, as the trial session will include high-intensity activities.

For details, call Siddharth Rawat at 7574980867.

Screening for people with Parkinson's

April marks World Parkinson's Awareness Month, highlighting the need to increase understanding of Parkinson's. Parivarthan for Parkinson's Foundation works actively to raise awareness and create a safe, supportive space for people living with Parkinson's and their families.

As part of its awareness efforts this April, Parivarthan is organising a Deep Brain Stimulation (DBS) screening session for people with Parkinson's on April 11. For more details and registration, contact 96000 52531.

Club sponsors autorickshaw



On March 5, Rotary Club of Chennai Velachery along with seven other Rotary Clubs (Chennai Korattur, Chennai Snehnam, Chennai Agaram, Chennai Utsav, Chennai Octave, Singara Chennai, United Chennai) sponsored an auto for Nancy. According to a release, Nancy is a widow and supports her child and two children of her sister. A 'Pink Auto' and cheque was given to Nancy by the District Governor of Rotary District 3233 Rtn. D. Devendran in the presence of

Past District Governor Rtn. A.P. Kanna; Pink Auto Project Chairman Rtn. Shanthi Selvam and President Rtn. Senthil Kumar Balraj. Rotary Club of Chennai Velachery also gave a cheque for ₹ 50,000 for a cancer patient. The Club has been conducting two months of spoken English class and AI course for 28 underprivileged girls by sponsoring for their course.

In nine months, the club has taken up 100 projects, added the release.



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